An IoT-Enabled Hybrid Soft Sensor for Real-Time Residual-Moisture Monitoring and Resource Accounting in Compact Wool Scouring Machines

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***Abstract*—Wool scouring requires substantial water and electricity, while residual moisture is normally assessed off-line. This study presents an Internet of Things (IoT) architecture and a hybrid soft-sensor formulation for a compact five-bowl wool scouring machine with an improved ribbed-drum squeezing device. A geometry-based prior is derived from 24 historical observations in a 2^3 factorial experiment, and a proposed regularised correction uses process measurements and sparse oven-dry samples. Reanalysis of the historical data gave a four-coefficient moisture model that passed the reported Cochran and lack-of-fit criteria; its in-sample RMSE was 0.59 percentage points across 24 readings (0.23 points across eight run means). Historical factory records reported 65–70 % versus 55–60 % post-squeezing moisture, 59.6 versus 14.0 m^3 of water per shift, and 13 versus 4.2 kW installed power for the existing and improved machines, respectively. These results describe the mechanical process, not performance of the proposed IoT system. Sensor calibration, held-out soft-sensor accuracy, packet delivery, network latency, and metered per-kilogram resource use remain to be measured in a prospective field study. The paper therefore reports a reproducible retrospective baseline and an implementation and validation protocol, not a validated factory IoT deployment.**

***Index Terms*—Industrial Internet of Things, soft sensor, wool scouring, edge computing, resource efficiency, textile manufacturing, digital twin.**

I. Introduction

PRIMARY wool processing—opening, scouring, squeezing and drying—determines the quality and cost of all downstream textile products. Scouring removes grease, suint and mineral dirt in a sequence of bowls filled with hot alkaline liquor; between bowls, squeezing devices remove the dirty liquor from the wool. Insufficient squeezing carries dirt into the next bowl, shortens liquor life and increases water and detergent consumption, and every percentage point of residual moisture must later be evaporated in the dryer. Scouring is a major contributor to the water footprint and life-cycle burden of wool products [3], [4], and its highly polluted effluent requires costly treatment [5], [6].

In regions such as Uzbekistan, where wool comes largely from Karakul sheep and is processed in small, decentralised plants, large centralised scouring lines are uneconomic. A compact, resource-saving machine with an improved squeezing device (ribbed squeeze drum, guide slat drum and wrapped mesh surface) was developed and patented in previous work [1], [2]; factory tests reported a reduction of residual moisture from 65–70 % to 55–60 % and of installed power from 13 to 4.2 kW. However, such machines are operated without sensors: operators cannot see liquor temperature or dirtiness, moisture is measured only by occasional oven-dry samples, and resource consumption is not accounted per kilogram of wool.

Related work. Industrial IoT increasingly moves analytics to the edge of the network [7], [8], and IoT/big-data frameworks have been demonstrated for health-state monitoring, fault detection and cloud–edge–device collaborative monitoring of manufacturing systems [9]–[11]. Low-cost nodes make such monitoring affordable [12], [13], and digital retrofitting is the practical route for legacy machines that cannot be replaced [14]. Digital twins built from sensor data extend this to model-based operation [15]–[17]. In the textile sector, Industry 4.0 and AI work concentrates on spinning, inspection and garment production [18]–[21]; energy benchmarking of wet processing in SMEs has been proposed but relies on manual audits [22].

Soft sensors estimate hard-to-measure quality variables from routine measurements [23]. Purely data-driven models need many labelled samples, which are expensive when the reference is a laboratory analysis [24]; gray-box and physics-informed models reduce this need and improve explainability [25], [26], while adaptive schemes keep the model calibrated online [27]. In IoT settings, self-improving soft sensors have been used to reduce costly measurements [28]. To our knowledge, however, no work instruments the wool scouring/squeezing stage, and none uses a design-of-experiments model of the machine as the prior of an IoT soft sensor.

Contributions.

1) A low-cost ($\approx$ US$ 200) IoT architecture for wool scouring machines with an ESP32 edge node, HTTP/MQTT transport, server-side analytics and an installable bilingual (EN/RU) web/mobile application.
2) A hybrid soft sensor for residual moisture that combines a 2^3 factorial regression model of the squeezing device (geometry prior) with an online, regularised correction

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for operating conditions, calibrated from sparse laboratory samples.
3) Real-time per-kilogram resource indicators (kWh/kg, L/kg) and rule-based fault alarms (heater failure, low level, dirty liquor, drum speed deviation).
4) Reanalysis of the historical mechanical-process baseline and an open-source IoT implementation at https://github.com/nasin0764-bit/woolwash-iot; the prospective field validation is defined but has not yet been completed.

II. Machine and Squeezing Model

The machine comprises five bowls with stated internal dimensions of $2500 \times 600 \times 515$ mm [1][TODO: the source also states 2.5 m^3 per bowl, whereas these dimensions give 0.77 m^3; confirm from the engineering drawing]; moving rakes (length 250 mm, historically calculated linear speed 0.15 m/s [1], to be verified in the field) transport the wool, and each bowl is followed by a squeezing device with a ribbed drum of diameter D, a mesh of hole diameter d and a drum–mesh gap h [1].

A. DoE prior

A 2^3 full-factorial experiment with three replicates ($N = 8$, $m = 3$) with coded factors $X_1 = (d - 2)/1$, $X_2 = (D - 250)/50$, $X_3 = (h - 3)/1$ (mm) gave, after Student's test ($t_{0.05;16} = 2.12$), the adequate model ($F = 0.71 < F_{0.05;4;16} = 3.01$)

$$W_0 = 57.31 + 0.81X_1 - 0.95X_2 + 0.30X_3 \quad [\%]. \tag{1}$$

B. Hybrid soft sensor

Equation (1) captures geometry only. During operation, moisture also depends on the drum angular speed ω, the feed rate q, the liquor temperature T and the liquor turbidity τ. With normalised deviations $\boldsymbol{\phi} = [(\omega - \omega_0)/s_\omega, (q - q_0)/s_q, (T - T_0)/s_T, (\tau - \tau_0)/s_\tau]^\top$ we model

$$\hat{W} = W_0(d, D, h) + \mathbf{w}^\top \boldsymbol{\phi} + c, \tag{2}$$

where $(\mathbf{w}, c)$ minimise $\sum_i (W_i - W_{0,i} - \mathbf{w}^\top \boldsymbol{\phi}_i - c)^2 + \lambda \|\mathbf{w}\|^2$ over laboratory samples W_i taken after the squeezer and dried at 105 °C. The model is refitted on the server each time a sample is added; with no samples it reduces to the DoE prior. The DoE regression is evaluated in Sec. V using its historical observations. A comparative assessment of the proposed hybrid estimator, a DoE-only baseline, ordinary ridge regression, and random forest requires temporally held-out field samples. No such model comparison is claimed from the retrospective geometry experiment.

III. IoT System Architecture

Fig. 1 shows the architecture. The node supports both HTTP and MQTT; the choice trades broker infrastructure against energy and overhead, as quantified in recent protocol comparisons [29], [30].

Proposed instrumentation. Five DS18B20 probes are positioned at mid-depth in the five bowls, approximately 10 cm from the wall and away from direct steam injection. Five waterproof JSN-SR04T rangefinders face the liquor surfaces from above the bowls; two turbidity probes are placed in side-stream sampling cups for bowls 1 and 2. A Hall-effect pickup on the first squeeze-drum shaft measures angular speed, a pulse flowmeter measures fresh-water make-up, and a PZEM-004T-type metering interface monitors machine electricity use. The design specifies an isolated 5-V DIN-rail supply and an IP65 enclosure; the nominal proposed acquisition interval is 2 s. Wiring, protective isolation, and mains connections require a qualified electrician.

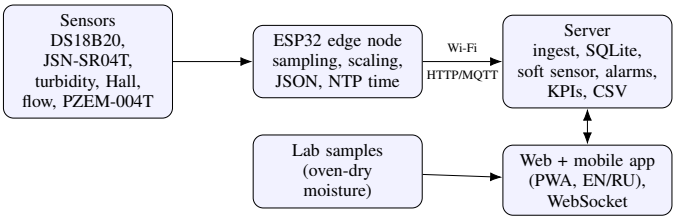


Fig. 1. Architecture of the proposed IoT framework.

Planned calibration. The probes will be checked against a reference thermometer, physical depth measurements, timed volumetric water collection (20-L reference), formazin turbidity standards, a handheld tachometer, and a revenue-grade power/energy meter, respectively. Calibration error and uncertainty will be estimated from the actual paired readings; they cannot be inferred from a manufacturer specification. The transmitted JSON payload size and the node's electricity consumption will be logged on installed hardware. The repository describes the planned hardware and commissioning protocol; these statements do not establish installation or accuracy.

IV. Experimental Setup

Retrospective material. The available historical evidence comprises a 2^3 geometry experiment (8 settings and 3 repeated moisture readings per setting) and mechanical-process factory comparisons reported for "Oqbo'tayeva Zulxumor" in Dehqonobod (Qashqadaryo) and "Hisori jun" in Oltinsoy (Surxondaryo), Uzbekistan [1]. No ESP32 telemetry, calibrated reference time series, commissioning date, or shift-level IoT log is included in those records.

Prospective validation design (not yet performed). The field protocol specifies at least five conventional-process shifts and ten improved-process shifts, when a comparable conventional machine is available. Spring and autumn wool are to be identified by batch; feed mass, operating hours and meter readings will be recorded for each shift. After squeezing, oven-dry reference moisture will be sampled approximately every 30 min at 105 °C using three laboratory replicates per sampling point. At least 60 labelled calibration observations and 20 additional observations on separate days are targeted for the held-out test set. Data must be divided by *day*, not randomly by replicate, to prevent leakage. Access-point distance, received signal strength (RSSI), sequence numbers, transmit and receive timestamps, and network interruptions will be recorded. These are prospective sample-size targets, not completed sample counts.

TABLE I
HISTORICAL 2^3 FACTORIAL DATA FOR RESIDUAL MOISTURE W (%) [1]. LEVELS $-1/0/+1$: $d = 1/2/3$ MM, $D = 200/250/300$ MM, $h = 2/3/4$ MM

Run	X_1	X_2	X_3	Replicates	Mean ± SD	$\hat{W}$
1	−	−	−	57.0, 57.5, 58.3	57.60 ± 0.66	57.15
2	+	−	−	58.3, 58.5, 58.7	58.50 ± 0.20	58.78
3	−	+	−	54.5, 55.2, 55.4	55.03 ± 0.47	55.26
4	+	+	−	57.2, 56.2, 57.4	56.93 ± 0.64	56.88
5	−	−	+	58.5, 57.2, 56.8	57.50 ± 0.89	57.74
6	+	−	+	59.8, 59.5, 59.0	59.43 ± 0.40	59.37
7	−	+	+	55.1, 56.3, 56.2	55.87 ± 0.67	55.85
8	+	+	+	57.1, 58.8, 57.0	57.63 ± 1.01	57.48

V. RESULTS I: RETROSPECTIVE BASELINE FROM HISTORICAL DISSERTATION DATA

All values in this section are transcribed from the historical experimental program [1] (Tables 3.7, 3.9, 3.13 and Sec. 4.1 therein) and reanalysed; they are *not* measurements of the IoT system and serve only as the physical-process reference and as the prior of the soft sensor. Measurements of the IoT system are reported exclusively in Sec. VI.

A. Factorial experiment

The 2^3 design (Table I) comprised three residual-moisture measurements per treatment, giving 24 observations over eight geometry combinations. Unweighted least squares on the eight run means gives the main-effects model (1) ($b_0 = 57.3125$, $b_1 = 0.8125$, $b_2 = -0.9458$, $b_3 = 0.2958$); the interaction terms were not significant ($|t| \le 1.08 < 2.12$). The within-run variances satisfy Cochran's homogeneity criterion ($G = 0.290 < 0.516$), and the model passes the lack-of-fit test ($F = 0.714 < F_{0.05;4,16} = 3.01$). These tests indicate no lack of fit at the eight measured corners but do not establish predictive accuracy outside the factor domain. The selected 2 mm/250 mm/3 mm geometry is an engineering compromise—narrower gaps caused wool jamming and damage, wider gaps reduced squeezing—and corresponds to a *predicted* residual moisture of 57.31 %; no separate center-point run was performed, and the minimum fitted corner (run 3, 55.26 %) is lower, so the setting is not the unconstrained statistical optimum.

B. Historical industrial observations

The improved design was tested at two enterprises in Uzbekistan (Qashqadaryo and Surxondaryo regions) [1]. Table II summarises the reported values and midpoint-based normalisations. Post-squeezing moisture decreased by about 10 percentage points and water use per shift by 76.5 %, but the improved line also had lower nominal throughput and lower clean-wool yield; the latter may reflect better impurity removal or fibre loss and cannot be resolved from aggregate values. Installed power is a nameplate value, not metered energy. The records lack matched batches, per-site variability and uncertainty, and are therefore descriptive evidence only—which is precisely the measurement gap the proposed IoT system addresses.

TABLE II
HISTORICAL COMPARISON REPORTED IN [1] (NOT IOT DATA)

Indicator	Existing	Improved	Change
Residual moisture (%)	65–70	55–60	−10 pp[a]
Water (m^3/shift)[b]	59.6	14.0	−76.5 %
Water reused (%)	70	80	+10 pp
Throughput (kg/h)[c]	700–800	400–450	−43.3 %[a]
Clean-wool yield (%)	64–66	60–62	−4 pp[a]
Installed power (kW)	13.0	4.2	−67.7 %
Water/throughput[d]	–	–	−58.5 %
Power/throughput[d]	–	–	−43.0 %
Scouring eff. (%)[e]	n/r	94.5; 92–95	–

[a] Range midpoints. [b] Units as in Table 3.13 of [1]; another table of the source uses litres per 450 kg. [c] Printed as "kg/s" in parts of the source; kg/h is the internally consistent reading. [d] Equal shift length and midpoint throughput assumed; nameplate power, not metered specific consumption. [e] Spring; autumn wool. n/r: not reported.

TABLE III
HISTORICAL IN-SAMPLE DOE FIT ONLY (NOT AN IOT OR HELD-OUT FIELD TEST)

Evaluation set	RMSE (pp)	MAE (pp)	R^2
Eight treatment means	0.229	0.185	0.969
All 24 historical readings	0.588	0.494	0.826

C. In-sample fit of the DoE prior

Table III reports residuals of model (1) *on the historical data from which its coefficients were estimated*. The 24-reading RMSE includes the variation among three repeats within each geometry. These values are not independent prediction errors; held-out accuracy is addressed only in Sec. VI.

D. Derived resource proxies

The only available water figures (59.6 and 14.0 m^3/shift) are historical reported process volumes with conflicting units elsewhere in the source. Under the additional assumptions of equal shift duration and midpoint throughputs of 750 and 425 kg/h, the ratio of water volume per kilogram for improved versus conventional processing is $(14/425)/(59.6/750) = 0.415$, or a 58.5 % lower *derived* water-to-throughput ratio. Actual L/kg cannot be established without the recorded shift duration and batch mass. Similarly, the nameplate-power/nominal-throughput proxies $13/750 = 0.0173$ and $4.2/425 = 0.00988$ kWh/kg assume full rated load and throughput; they are *not* metered specific energy. No IoT-versus-non-IoT savings or significance test is claimed.

VI. RESULTS II: PROSPECTIVE FACTORY IOT VALIDATION

This section is reserved for measurements collected with the deployed IoT system at the factory. No value from Sec. V is reused here, and simulator output is excluded. **Status: not yet performed**; the subsections define what will be reported. [TODO: Replace each subsection with measured results (n, mean ± SD, test days) once the field campaign is complete.]

A. Held-out soft-sensor accuracy

The hybrid estimator, a DoE-only baseline, ordinary ridge regression and random forest will be evaluated on day-separated held-out oven-dry samples, using identical test days and reference measurements for every model, and reported as RMSE, MAE and R^2. The soft-sensor prediction for each sample is stored *before* that sample is used for retraining, giving an out-of-sample error. No field accuracy has yet been measured.

B. Metered resource indicators

Shift-level $\mathrm{kWh/kg} = \Delta E/M$ and $\mathrm{L/kg} = 1000\Delta V/M$ will be computed from metered electricity ΔE, water ΔV and weighed processed mass M. These values remain unreported.

C. Communication performance

The proposed logger attaches a packet sequence number, boot identifier and transmission timestamp to each message, allowing the server to identify sequence gaps and calculate delivery ratio $100N_{\mathrm{received}}/N_{\mathrm{sent}}$. For clock-synchronised edge and server devices, one-way delay is $t_{\mathrm{receive}} - t_{\mathrm{transmit}}$; the protocol will report the median, 95th-percentile delay, outage intervals and RSSI distribution. The repository's simulator can exercise the software pipeline, but simulator logs are excluded from factory performance analysis. No measured message-delivery percentage, latency distribution, outage duration or edge-node energy demand is available.

D. Fault detection

The design includes rule-based alerts for heater-off, low liquor level, abnormal drum speed and excessive turbidity. After risk assessment, supervised fault injection will be performed on an instrumented machine without disabling safety interlocks. Detection delay will be measured from the independently recorded fault onset to the first correctly logged alert; false-alarm rate will use normal-operation monitoring time as its denominator. No experimental detection delays, sensitivity or false-alarm rates have yet been measured. Simulated fault demonstrations validate code paths only, not factory detection performance.

VII. Discussion and Limitations

The historical data establish a reproducible design-of-experiments baseline and an engineering rationale for the ribbed-drum and mesh configuration. They do not validate the IoT hardware, hybrid estimator, networking or any claimed operational savings from IoT feedback. The in-sample error metrics in Table III are not a substitute for held-out accuracy, and the water volumes are inconsistent between source tables. The improved machine also has lower nominal throughput and clean-wool yield, which may reflect increased impurity removal or undesired fibre loss; no matched fibre-quality assays establish the cause. Further limits include seasonal changes in greasy wool, sensor fouling in hot alkaline liquor, Wi-Fi attenuation and interference in wet industrial halls, and the absence of multi-site deployment evidence. Access tokens, TLS, role-based access and backups should be verified on the actual factory network rather than treated as demonstrated security controls. Hence the present work is a system design and retrospective baseline study, not evidence of proven IoT effectiveness.

VIII. Conclusion

An ESP32-based architecture and a DoE-informed hybrid soft-sensor formulation were specified for a compact wool-scouring machine. Reanalysis of 24 historical moisture observations confirmed an adequate four-term geometry model; the in-sample RMSE was 0.588 percentage points across individual readings. Historical records also suggest lower residual moisture and reduced water volume per shift for the improved *mechanical* process, subject to data comparability and unit limitations. No field measurements yet establish the accuracy, reliability, latency, alarm performance or per-kilogram resource benefits of the proposed IoT system. Independent, day-separated factory validation with calibrated sensors and metered consumption is required before such performance claims can be made.

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